(v) **Bharat Nirman:** A major programme to focus on the agricultural and rural infrastructure (totalling six items) was launched by the Government in 2005 with the ultimate intention of strengthening rural economy.

(vi) **Others:** Similarly, many time-bound programmes and schemes have been launched since 2002 which focus on the agriculture sector and the rural areas from different angles—education, electricity, wage, as well as self-employment, healthcare, communication, etc.

Looking at the size of population depending upon the agriculture sector, comparatively longer government apathy to the agricultural realities and the late start of reform process in it make things very tough to effect visible changes in the sector in a short time. It also requires comparatively longer period of time. We will then be able to see the visible results of the policy shift as well as the results of the economic reforms in the agriculture sector provided there remains a continued political commitment to the cause. One positive development of the last decade has been that India has been able to reach a silent political consensus on some of the very important aspects of development (for example—on the process of economic reforms, foreign investment, deregulation, social justice, emphasis on agricuture, priority to the social sector, etc.) which gives us hope that the economy will be able to take care of the agriculture sector in due course and more accelerated growth and development can be achieved.

PLANNED AND MIXED ECONOMY

Independent India was declared to be a planned and a mixed economy. India needed national planning, it was decided by the political leadership almost a decade before independence.[14] India was not only facing regional disparities at the level of resources but inter-regional disparities were also prevalent, since centuries. Mass poverty could only be remedied once the government started the process of economic planning. Economic planning was thus considered an established tool of doing away with such disparities.

Basically, it was the abject poverty of the masses which made the government go for planning so that it could play an active role in the